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All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination. There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

AHEAD OF SEPTEMBER SUMMIT

China, Russia, Iran in Delhi next week for huddle of BRICS NSAs

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 18

CHINESE FOREIGN Minister Wang Yi, Russian NSA Sergei Shoigu and Iranian Supreme National Security Council Deputy Secretary Nezamipour will be in New Delhi for the meeting of the BRICS NSAs on June 22-23, which will set the stage for the summit of BRICS leaders in India in September.

India holds the rotating presidency of the BRICS bloc this year. Its members include Brazil, China, Egypt, Ethiopia, India, Indonesia, Iran, Russia, Saudi Arabia, South Africa and the United Arab Emirates.

Wang, who is also Beijing's Special Representative on the India-China boundary issue, is expected to hold bilateral talks with NSA Ajit Doval during the visit. Doval will host the meeting of the NSAs.

Doval and Wang are also India and China's representatives for boundary talks. PTI FILE

Wang was unable to attend the meeting of BRICS Foreign Ministers last month because he had to be in Beijing for the visit of US President Donald Trump.

Sources said Wang's visit is

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INTERIM PACT REOPENS HORMUZ, ENDS BLOCKADE

Deal ending war gives Iran critical economic lifeline

Tehran can sell oil freely, will get rich incentives if it agrees to new nuclear pact

Lee Keath
Cairo, June 18

US President Donald Trump in Versailles and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian in Tehran sign the agreement to end the war. PTI, ANI

RELATED REPORTS, PAGES 15, 16

THE INTERIM deal reached by the US and Iran to end their war will reopen the Strait of Hormuz and bring the two adversaries back to the negotiating table over Tehran's nuclear programme, according to details released by both countries.

It will also give Iran an immediate benefit, allowing it to sell its oil freely again.

Besides the new oil revenue for Iran, the two sides are more or less back where they were three-and-half months ago — before Israel and the US launched their war, which has left thousands dead across the region, triggered a global energy crisis and shaken the American economy.

Iran and the US will enter a 60-day period of negotiations,

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ECONOMY PAGE 17

EMERGENCY FUEL SUPPLY TO BE ROLLED BACK ONCE WEST ASIA SITUATION STABILISES

EXPRESS investigation

Private schools, pricey coaching, family business, MNC jobs: They also cracked EWS list in UPSC exam

Daughter of railway porter to son of security guard to IIT graduate, MNC employee: Rs 8-lakh income bar raises questions of fairness in eligibility

Shyamlal Yadav
New Delhi, June 18

FOR EVERY candidate who cracked India's civil services this year under the Economically Weaker Section quota, the son of a security guard or the daughter of a railway porter, there are many others on the same quota list whose backgrounds tell a different story: sons and daughters of businessmen, IIT graduates, alumni of private schools in the city charging over a lakh a year in fees.

There were 104 candidates selected in the Civil Services Examination 2025 under the 10 per cent quota for the Economically Weaker Section (EWS) — those from general category families with an annual income of less than Rs 8 lakh. An investigation by *The Indian Express* has found a gap between the scheme's stated purpose and the profiles of many it has come to benefit.

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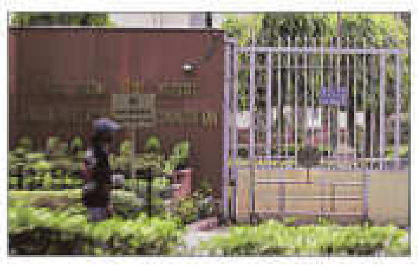

The UPSC office on Delhi's Shahjahan Road. TASHI TOBGYAL

• The Quota Data

104 EWS candidates selected in 2025 civil services exam.

67 attended well-known coaching institutes, annual fees up to Rs 2.65 lakh.

28 candidates' parents have businesses — shops and trading to steel fabrication, cloth and confectionery.

10 candidates held private jobs, including in MNCs.

14 graduates or postgraduates from IITs, and at least three from NITs.

Why top court had questioned Rs 8-lakh limit

Who qualifies under EWS?
The Economically Weaker Section (EWS) quota, notified in 2019, grants 10% reservation in government jobs and educational institutions to persons from the general category not covered under SC, ST or OBC reservations. It covers applicants and their families.

E. A 2019 office memorandum of the Centre's Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions clarifies, "The term 'Family' for this purpose will include the person who seeks benefit of reservation, his/her parents and siblings below the age of 18 years as also his/her spouse and children below the age of 18 years."

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Iran

and hanging over them will be the question of whether US President Donald Trump can wrest a better deal than the 2015 nuclear accord he scuttled eight years ago.

Trump signed a physical copy of the deal Wednesday while dining with French President Emmanuel Macron at the Palace of Versailles.

In Tehran, President Masoud Pezeshkian signed the document, according to the state-run IRNA news agency, which posted an image of him holding up the deal with his signature and Trump's.

Under the agreement, the Strait of Hormuz will reopen, and the US will lift its blockade of Iranian ports – both of which should push gas prices down. Passage through the waterway will be toll-free for 60 days, and the deal doesn't preclude fees after that, according to US officials who spoke on the condition of anonymity.

Iran's closure of the strait, through which around a fifth of the world's traded oil supplies passed before the war, proved perhaps its strongest weapon. It drove up global fuel prices, made food and other products like fertilizer more expensive, and helped push US inflation to 4% ahead of this fall's midterm congressional elections.

With the deal in place, the Islamic Republic has survived the most serious attempt ever by Israel and the United States to topple its government, despite the thundering opening volleys of the war that killed Iran's supreme leader and other top officials. The deal immediately waives, but doesn't eliminate, sanctions that Trump imposed on Iran's oil exports, allowing it once again to sell its crude on the world market and restoring a revenue stream worth billions.

Last year, Iran earned an estimated $45 billion from oil sales. But it had only one major buyer, China, and had to ship its crude through a shadow fleet of tankers to elude sanctions, eating into its profits. Under the blockade since April, its exports have nearly ground to a halt.

With the waiver, Iran will likely be able to find more customers and sell its oil for higher prices. The draft agreement calls for Iran's highly enriched uranium to be "downblended" — or diluted — under the supervision of the International Atomic Energy Agency. The two sides will work out the details during their negotiations as well as generally discuss Iran's enrichment programme, which it says it has a right to continue.

Iran developed the material in response to Trump's scuttling of Tehran's 2015 nuclear accord with world powers that prevented it from enriching uranium to high levels. He criticized the deal for giving Iran a huge windfall.

But the interim deal outlines even more lucrative incentives if Iran reaches a new nuclear agreement.

One is the eventual lifting of all international sanctions, which would seem to go further than the 2015 accord. That agreement lifted sanctions related to Iran's nuclear programme but kept others in place over what the US alleged were Tehran's support for terrorism and rights abuses.

The interim pact also promises a $300 billion fund for postwar reconstruction. It's not clear where that money will come from – but Trump said the US would not contribute.

The deal also promises to unfreeze billions of dollars worth of Iranian assets held abroad under a procedure the two sides will work out, according to the text provided by US officials.

The Trump administration said its war aims were to "obliterate" Iran's missile arsenal, "sever its support" for armed proxies in the region, "annihilate its navy," and ensure it never acquires a nuclear weapon.

The seven weeks of US-Israeli bombardment are believed to have heavily damaged Iran's missile arsenal and production facilities as well as other parts of its military. How heavily isn't known, though, and Iran continued to fire on Israel as recently as last week.

Meanwhile, Iran's ties with its militant proxies – Hezbollah in Lebanon, the Houthis in Yemen and Shiite militias in Iraq – appear as strong as ever.

Neither the missile arsenal nor Iran's support for its allies appears to be on the table in the upcoming negotiations.

The deal calls for an end to the war in Lebanon, where Israel has been fighting Hezbollah. However, Israel and Hezbollah aren't parties to the agreement. Iran insists Israel must withdraw from the large swath of southern Lebanon it is occupying, but the interim deal doesn't explicitly require that and only ensures Lebanon's "territorial integrity."

Israel has vowed to keep troops in Lebanon, while Hezbollah says it is committed to resisting Israel "until full withdrawal is achieved." Fighting between the two could derail the deal unless the US and Iran can rein in their respective allies. **AP**

NSAs

also a signal that Chinese President Xi Jinping is likely to visit India for the summit of the BRICS leaders on September 12-13. Russia has already conveyed that President Vladimir Putin will be attending the meeting.

In Beijing, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lin Jian told a media briefing Thursday that Wang will exchange views with other BRICS member states on the current international security situation and major international and regional issues.

The meeting will also discuss joint responses to traditional and non-traditional security challenges and make preparations for the BRICS summit in September, Lin said. "Amid a transforming and volatile world with many security challenges on the rise, BRICS countries standing at the forefront of the global south are committed to safeguarding world peace," Lin said.

UPSC

The successful candidates include those whose presence affirms the scheme's effectiveness as a stepping stone for the poor — from the son of a security guard to the daughter of a railway porter and the son of a bus conductor.

However, there are also those on the list whose presence raises questions on their eligibility and has prompted a debate within sections of the Union Public Service Commission on the need to tighten the rules or ensure more robust due diligence.

The investigation reveals that a significant number of successful EWS candidates in 2025 attended well-known civil services coaching institutes (64.4 per cent); underwent private schooling (44.4 per cent); had parents who ran businesses (26.9 per cent); and held jobs in the corporate sector (9.6 per cent).

The EWS quota, introduced in 2019, reserves 10 per cent of seats for candidates from general-category families with a gross annual income below Rs 8 lakh, subject to asset-ownership conditions.

This newspaper investigated the social media profiles, coaching institute records, and school and college details, of all the 104 candidates who qualified under the EWS quota this time from the list of 958 selected in 2025 -- the latest completed cycle of the examination for which the results were declared in March this year.

Consider the key findings:

- At least 67 candidates attended well-known coaching institutes in Delhi and other cities, including Vajiram & Ravi, Vajirao & Reddy and Drishti IAS, where annual fees can reach up to Rs 2.65 lakh.

Overall, at least 84 of the 104 candidates availed formal civil services coaching, with many attending multiple institutes such as ForumIAS, NextIAS, KingMakers IAS and UPSC Wallah. This count excludes those who attended government-sponsored or university-run programmes.

Some institutes do offer scholarships but these are restricted.

- At least 46 candidates completed their schooling at private schools in the National Capital Region and state capitals such as Lucknow, Raipur and Jaipur. *The Indian Express* found that these schools' fees range from Rs 45,000 to Rs 1.5 lakh annually.
- Parents of at least 28 candidates own businesses — from shops and trading to steel fabrication, cloth and confectionery. At least five of these families are based in the NCR, one in a state capital, and eight others at various district headquarters.
- At least 10 candidates were employed in the private sector, including some multinationals and large software and construction firms, before beginning their UPSC preparation, some of them on substantial salaries.
- At least 14 of the 104 candidates are graduates or postgraduates from IITs, and at least three from National Institutes of Technology (NITs). At least 27 studied at Delhi University and at least three at JNU in Delhi.

'Purpose will be defeated'

The same list also includes candidates who fit the scheme's purpose — *The Indian Express* is not publishing the names of the candidates to protect their identities.

- One is the son of a retired army man who now works as a security guard. Another is the son of a school bus conductor. A woman candidate is the daughter of a former railway porter. Others come from families of daily-wage labourers and unemployed parents.
- At least seven studied at Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalayas, which are residential government schools primarily for rural children. Several are Hindi-medium students from rural backgrounds with farmer fathers.
- The parents of 29 candidates are farmers, including seven from UP, four each from Bihar, Haryana and Madhya Pradesh, and two from the same family in a southern state.

Records show that the 104 candidates hail from across the country, including UP (25), Bihar (17), MP (14), Haryana (9), Rajasthan (8), Gujarat (5), Uttarakhand (4), Karnataka (4) and Kerala (3).

Former and current civil services officers said the ability of many EWS candidates to sustain multi-year preparations and premium coaching, especially in the national capital, and afford private schooling reinforces questions about whether the quota is being accessed by those with relatively "better financial and educational backgrounds".

"EWS relies on income and asset criteria. Issuing authorities must exercise rigorous due diligence, going beyond self-declarations and Income Tax returns, when verifying claims. If well-to-do individuals corner this benefit, the entire purpose of EWS reservation will be defeated," Satyananda Mishra, former Chief Information Commissioner and ex-Secretary, Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT), told *The Indian Express*.

Rs 8-lakh limit

The key eligibility criteria are: gross annual income must be below Rs 8 lakh; the family must not own 5 acres of agricultural land or more; must not own a residential flat of 1,000 sq ft or more; must not own a residential plot of 100 sq yards or more in a notified municipality; and must not own a residential plot of 200 sq yards or more in areas outside notified municipalities.

Why were questions raised over the income mark?

According to experts, a credible determination of economic backwardness has been a challenge.

On October 21, 2021, while hearing a petition on NEET-PG admissions, a Supreme Court bench headed by Justice D Y Chandrachud asked the Government to explain how it had fixed Rs 8 lakh per annum as the income eligibility limit for EWS reservation. "You can't just pull out Rs 8 lakh from anywhere. There must be some data -- sociological, demographic," the court said. The court also pointed out that Rs 8 lakh was also the cut-off for the OBC creamy layer, and observed that while OBCs suffer from social and educational backwardness, EWS candidates are not socially or educationally backward.

In January 2022, the Centre submitted in the court that while income from salaries and agricultural land is excluded while computing income for the OBC creamy layer, income from all sources is included for EWS. It cited a report by a three-member review committee it had set up, which determined that "threshold of Rs 8 lakh of annual family income, in the current situation, seems reasonable for determining EWS".

AT VIVATECH, PM BATS FOR SIMPLIFYING REGULATIONS, EASE OF DOING BUSINESS

In era of disruption, technology must deliver for all: Modi in Paris

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 18

UNVEILING THE country's technology vision for the world, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said Thursday that India believes that "in this era of disruption, technology must deliver for all".

Addressing the Paris VivaTech event which he attended with French President Emmanuel Macron, Modi said, "Our approach is clear. Our government will enable and industry will innovate. Startups will disrupt and global partners will scale with us. Together, we will move faster than ever. I call upon everyone in this room to take the lead. Work with India and deliver for all."

"When it comes to technology, along with innovation, what matters is access. Technology can lead to progress, only when it is democratized. India believes that in this era of disruption, technology must deliver for all," he said.

Citing the example of AI, he said, "AI must improve lives, widen access, drive growth and also help us sustain a healthy planet. Our participation as the AI Country Partner at VivaTech 2026 reflects this very vision. For India, AI means 'All Inclusive'."

VivaTech Summit, Europe's largest technology and startup event, is hosting an Indian pavilion, the largest there this year.

Modi's participation in both Bharat Innovates and VivaTech Summit spotlights India as a global hub for innovation, digital transformation and entrepreneurship, and is expected to catalyse new partnerships between Indian and European technology ecosystems.

PM Narendra Modi at VivaTech 2026 Summit in Paris. PTI

Recalling that 2026 is a special year for India and Europe, with the historic India-EU Free Trade Agreement and the India-France Year of Innovation, he said France is an important bridge that is bringing the tech ecosystems of India and Europe closer.

"Our technology solutions are delivering prosperity at the grassroots level... From space technologies to nuclear energy, we are expanding the frontiers of human capability. With over 200,000 start-ups, India is one of the most vibrant ecosystems in the world," he said.

Underlining that India is an open society and the world's largest talent pool, he said, "We are simplifying regulations and ensuring ease of doing business. From innovation to commercialisation, we are supporting private enterprise through targeted incentives of over 50 billion dollars."

Earlier in the day, Modi met leading business executives in Paris and held discussions on investment opportunities and expansion plans in India.

The discussions with the CEOs of the French companies focused on strengthening cooperation across sectors ranging from shipping and logistics to railways, construction and artificial intelligence, according to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA).

Modi is currently in France, where he participated in the G7 Summit and held talks with several world leaders including US President Donald Trump.

Among those who met Modi in Paris Thursday was Rodolphe Saade, Chairman and CEO of CMA CGM, the container shipping and logistics major. The discussions focused on maritime shipping, logistics and global supply chains.

Modi also met Benoit Bazin, Chairman and CEO of Saint-Gobain, and discussed opportunities in the materials and construction sector, with a particular emphasis on sustainability.

He separately met Martin Sion, CEO of Alstom, and discussed opportunities in mobility and railway modernisation. He also met Arthur Mensch, co-founder and CEO of Mistral AI, and highlighted opportunities in India's "growing AI ecosystem".

PM Narendra Modi and French President Emmanuel Macron visit the exhibition area at VivaTech 2026, in Paris on Thursday. ANI

Bharat is now a trusted global partner for world, PM tells diaspora

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 18

UNDERLINING THE uncertainty and disruptions that defined prevailing geopolitical conditions, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday sought to stress on the trust between nations and equal partnership with the Global South for the larger benefit of mankind – adding that Bharat had emerged as a trusted global partner.

Addressing the Indian diaspora, which he defined as the bridge between India and Europe, at an event in Paris, PM Modi also sought to underline that while India's status as a trusted partner had led to the invigoration of its business relationships with several nations, the aspirations and ambitions of 140 crore Indians were the fuel for its continuing journey towards development back home.

"There was (a) time when relations between nations were defined by business. Today, along with business, trust has become as important. Every nation wants a reliable supply chain, stable partnership... every nation is looking for a partner in whom trust can be reposed for the long term. And in this era, India is emerging as a trusted partner in the world," he said.

"Today, the world is going through an era of uncertainty and disruptions. In such a time, India and France's partnership is becoming a strong pillar of trust, stability and cooperation," he added.

The last 12 years, he said, were an era underlined by the capability, dreams and aspirations of 140 crore Indians and had witnessed India's GDP, the number of its airports and universities double even as its highway construction speed has gone up three times, and metro network four times.

"Exports have increased 35 times... mobile manufacturing units have seen an increase of 100 times. Bharat is now the world's second largest mobile phone manufacturer. This speed and progress have resulted in India becoming the world's fastest growing major economy," he said.

During the G7 Summit in Evian, PM Modi said that he had stressed on making trust-based partnerships, urging that it was required to move forward with nations of the Global South as equal partners.

India's message at the Summit, he said, was that global governance will only be effective when it is inclusive; global growth will only be sustainable when it is shared and global technology will only be beneficial for mankind when it is trusted.

"New energy is visible in business relations between India and the rest of the world. India's trade with France is increasing continuously; in the last few years, India has signed free trade agreements with several nations. Whether it is the European Union, United Kingdom – India is signing agreements with each nation and region," he said.

Underlining the strengthening bond between India and France, he said, "From defence to space and nuclear, AI and critical minerals to high-speed railways, we will move forward together in every field. Whether it is solar energy or cooperation in the field of AI, India and France, together, are developing solutions which are for the benefit of all mankind."

After co-chairing the Global AI Summit, both nations were, next year, scheduled to launch the Trishna satellite.

"Trishna satellite will contribute towards ensuring global food and water security... your contribution in all these government-to-government initiatives is very significant," he told the audience.

Andhra Pradesh opens doors to doctors nationwide, scraps state registration requirement

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, June 18

IN A first in the country, doctors from across India will be allowed to practice in Andhra Pradesh without them registering independently with Andhra Pradesh Medical Council. Doctors from other states will also be exempted from taking a No Objection Certificate from the state or union territory they are registered with before practicing in Andhra Pradesh.

With this, Andhra Pradesh becomes the first state to remove registration barriers for doctors from across India.

An order to this effect was issued on June 11 by the department of health and family welfare in AP. The order read: "In pursuance of the policy decision of the Government under PA-19 (Priority Area -19) and in order to facilitate ease of practice for qualified medical practitioners, the Government of Andhra Pradesh hereby notifies that any person possessing a recognized medical qualification and holding a valid registration with any State Medical Council or Union Territory Medical Council in India shall be permitted to practice in the State of Andhra Pradesh".

Doctors will also be exempted from taking a NOC from the state or UT they are registered with before practising in Andhra Pradesh

The current law requires doctors registered under a state medical council to deregister from their state of practice and secure a No Objection Certificate to reregister and practice in another state. This is the norm that the new order seeks to change.

It states that the Andhra Pradesh Medical Council "may obtain such particulars, declarations and information through its online portal as may be required for verification and maintenance of records".

This, however, does not mean that the state will exempt "any medical practitioner from compliance with the provisions of the National Medical Commission Act, 2019, applicable regulations, professional ethics, disciplinary proceedings or any other law for the time being in force".

The new rules, according to experts, will help open Andhra's doors to doctors across India and make the state a destination for medical tourism.

"The process of taking No Objection Certificate from one state and reapplying for registration in the state where one would like to serve, is a cumbersome process," Dr Babu KV, who is a registered medical practitioner in Kerala and central working committee member of Indian Medical Association.

Dr Babu has written to the Medical Council of India to take Andhra Pradesh as an example and exempt doctors from taking medical registration in different states.

He said: "As such there is no necessity of registration in more than one State Medical Council because any doctor, who has registered with any State Medical Council is automatically registered in the Indian Medical Register and also by virtue of Section 27of the IMC Act, 1956, a person, whose name is included in the IMR, can practise anywhere in India".

The separate registration processes in each of the states makes practice difficult for doctors, Dr Babu said. He added: "I sincerely hope that the NMC will take this seriously and allow doctors to freely practice in any state of India once any state has granted a registration."

Look beyond winners & losers in US, Iran

THE ISLAMABAD Memorandum of Understanding, signed remotely on Wednesday by US President Donald Trump and his Iranian counterpart, Masoud Pezeshkian, has triggered astonishment across the world. Critics in Washington argue that the agreement offers substantial upfront concessions to Tehran while leaving Iran's most consequential commitments to future implementation. The contrast between Trump's earlier rhetoric of "unconditional surrender" and the eventual outcome has fuelled criticism within his own political coalition. The backlash is not confined to the US. In Israel, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who had nudged Washington into the war, confronts a major political setback. Less discussed are the implications for America's Arab partners in the Gulf, caught in the crossfire. If the MoU evolves into a broader rapprochement between Washington and Tehran, its long-term consequences for the Gulf could be positive and profound. The agreement reflects a recognition in Washington that a prolonged confrontation with Iran carries high costs. Energy uncertainty, pressures on the global economy, and concerns about domestic political consequences appear to have reinforced the case for diplomacy in Washington. Whatever the criticisms of the deal, Trump has demonstrated the will to step back from escalation. Whether he has the political wits to manage the domestic and international consequences of this shift remains to be seen.

In India, the debate should move beyond questions of winners and losers. That Iran successfully leveraged its strategic position around the Strait of Hormuz does not mean the broader balance of power has shifted decisively against the US. More significant is the possibility that Washington and Tehran may be exploring a new grand bargain after nearly five decades of hostility. Trump has spoken in unusually conciliatory terms about Iran's future place in the global economy if it abandons the pursuit of nuclear weapons. Important voices in Tehran are also signalling the need for a new direction. Iranian Parliament Speaker Mohammad Ghalibaf has argued that Iran must focus more on national economic development and less on perpetual regional confrontation. If such sentiments gain traction, they could create the foundations for a broader accommodation between Iran, the US, and Tehran's Arab neighbours.

Peace between Washington and Tehran, and a reduction of tensions between Iran and the Arab states, would help stabilise India's western neighbourhood, strengthen energy security, improve regional connectivity, and expand opportunities for trade and investment across the Gulf. Prime Minister Narendra Modi was right to welcome Trump's efforts to end the crisis. A more stable Gulf could become the foundation for greater cooperation between South Asia and the wider Middle East — a strategic outcome that would serve India's long-term interests.

Washington-Tehran MoU is a relief, but flashpoints remain

R SWAMINATHAN

THE 14-point Memorandum of Understanding (MoU), digitally signed last Sunday on US President Donald Trump's 80th birthday, was again signed by him early Thursday morning our time at a Versailles dinner hosted by French President Emmanuel Macron. Though Iran was not represented in Versailles, it also released the text around the same time. This official release came after global media outlets leaked the full text yesterday morning.

According to the MoU, a final agreement is to be negotiated within 60 days, extendable by mutual consent. The MoU includes a commitment by Iran that it will never produce nuclear weapons. It also says the US will lift its naval blockade of Iran fully within 30 days (which it has already done), that the movement of ships through the Strait of Hormuz will be restored to full capacity within 30 days, and that the US will issue waivers for exports of Iranian crude oil and other products and services.

In addition, Iran and the US, together with their allies (read Israel, though it is not a party to the deal), will permanently and immediately end the war on all fronts, including Lebanon, and cease all hostile action or threats of force against each other. The MoU also specifies that both sides will address the fate of enriched material, including Iran's nuclear needs. The final agreement will be approved through a binding resolution of the UN Security Council.

Notably, the MoU does not include specific provisions to discuss the curtailment of Iran's ballistic missile capabilities or its support for regional proxies. However, these issues could still be raised during the negotiations due to pressure from Republicans, Israel, and the Gulf countries.

The MoU primarily restores the status quo ante. Before the commencement of Operation Epic Fury on February 28, the Strait of Hormuz was open for free passage with no US blockade. The US and Iran had just completed the third round of their discussions on nuclear and other issues on February 26, with a tentative fourth round being considered for March 2. The outcome of the war is that nuclear negotiations have essentially returned to the starting point, with one key difference: The US is now waiving sanctions on the export of Iranian oil and allied products, while offering assurances of relief on frozen Iranian assets.

Further, during the discussions preceding the war, the US insisted on zero uranium enrichment, while Iran maintained that it had an inherent right to enrich. However, Iran showed a willingness to compromise by offering to transfer its 60 per cent enriched uranium to a third country and suspend enrichment for several years. In the forthcoming 60-day negotiations, Iran is likely to agree to its pre-war concessions, with a significant condition of its own: It will now reject transferring the enriched material abroad, opting instead to down-blend it below 5 per cent while eventually agreeing to a 10-to-15-year enrichment suspension.

Notably, the MoU does not include specific provisions to discuss the curtailment of Iran's ballistic missile capabilities or its support for regional proxies

The key new element is Iran's explicit declaration that it will never produce nuclear weapons. While this commitment is already implicit in the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT), to which Iran has been a party since 1970, and has been repeatedly reaffirmed by Tehran — including through an oral fatwa attributed to Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in 2003 — the difference now is that Iran is effectively waiving the NPT's standard withdrawal clause. Tehran has never given notice to withdraw from the treaty despite major conflicts in June 2025 and this year.

A major concession that Iran has secured upfront is a ceasefire in Lebanon, where it suffered immense strategic damage following Israel's killing of Hezbollah chief Hassan Nasrallah in 2024 and the near-decimation of the group's military capabilities.

While the MoU could be seen as "Advantage Iran", its conclusion has already brought significant domestic and economic benefits for Trump. Oil prices, which skyrocketed to $126 per barrel during the conflict, have plunged below $80, triggering a major stock-market rally. Further, the US secured a binding commitment from Iran never to produce nuclear weapons. This comes after a military campaign in which the US inflicted massive damage on Iran's military infrastructure, eliminated key leadership figures, and enforced a sustained blockade that caused severe hardship in Iran.

Trump's announcement last Sunday that the MoU had been concluded sparked widely varying reactions across the US. While the MAGA base backed the deal as a triumphant validation of Trump's "maximum pressure" strategy, traditional Republicans remained conflicted — mirroring warnings from the CIA director that Tehran might use the 60-day pause as a strategic stalling tactic.

Concurrently, Democrats blasted the framework as flimsy and dangerously vague. Meanwhile, the broader American public responded with a mix of relief over the end of the conflict and scepticism regarding Iran's willingness to comply with its nuclear concessions.

However, the official release of the MoU's terms has already sharpened domestic reactions within the US, where critics have termed it a "jaw-dropping humiliation" and a "surrender". This severe criticism, combined with fierce opposition from an Israel that feels it stands to lose the most, has significant potential to derail the upcoming 60-day negotiations.

A major flashpoint will be Lebanon, as Iran is expected to insist on a complete Israeli withdrawal during the talks. While Trump took a position in the recent past that Israel would have the right to retaliate in the event of attacks by Hezbollah, he is now proposing to look to Syria to handle the militant group — a strategy that seeks to exploit the deep animosity between the current Syrian leadership and Hezbollah. Another issue of friction will be Iran's assertion that the Strait of Hormuz will operate under joint Iranian-Omani sovereignty — a geopolitical stance completely unacceptable to Washington.

Thus, while much of the world is cheering the MoU in hopes of a lasting peace, significant hurdles remain in achieving it.

The writer is former governor of India to the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA), Vienna, former ambassador to Egypt and former permanent representative to the Arab League

A decade of empowerment, from reform to rozgar

MANSUKH MANDAVIYA

OVER THE past 12 years, under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India has undergone a remarkable transformation driven by empowerment, good governance, and inclusive development. From being counted among the Fragile Five economies in 2013, it has emerged as the fastest-growing major economy, built one of the largest start-up ecosystems, become a leader in digital public infrastructure, and strengthened its standing on the global stage.

At the heart of this transformation is India's yuva shakti. Recognising the potential of the demographic dividend, the government has launched transformative initiatives like Make in India, Digital India, Startup India, Skill India, PM Mudra Yojana, and the National Career Service portal. Combined with investments in infrastructure, innovation, and technology, these have expanded opportunities for employment, entrepreneurship, and skill development.

India's growth story is also a story of rising employment. Research shows that between 2017-18 and 2023-24, India's employment elasticity stood at 1.11, meaning that every 1 per cent increase in Gross Value Added was accompanied by a 1.11 percent rise in employment. This marks a sharp improvement over the employment elasticity of 0.008 between 2011-12 and 2017-18.

According to RBI KLEMS data, more than 17 crore jobs were created between 2014 and 2024, compared to 2.9 crore during 2004-14. The employment rate increased from 46.8 percent in 2017-18 to 57.4 percent in 2025, while unemployment declined to around 3.1 percent, below the global average of 4.8 percent. EPFO payroll data further indicate that more than 8 crore formal-sector jobs were added between 2017 and 2025.

By putting money directly into workers' pockets, PMVBRY makes jobs more attractive. Financial incentives for employers can generate positive cyclical impacts on industrial growth

The story of New India is equally about ensuring people are protected through a robust social-security system. Social-security coverage increased from 25 crore people (19 per cent of the population) in 2015 to more than 94 crore (64.3 per cent) in 2025. In recognition of this achievement, India received the International Social Security Association's Award for Outstanding Achievement in Social Security in 2025.

The Modi government, in the first budget of its third term, introduced the most ambitious employment initiative in independent India's history: The Pradhan Mantri Viksit Bharat Rozgar Yojana (PMVBRY). With an outlay of nearly Rs 1 lakh crore, PMVBRY aims to support the creation of more than 3.5 crore employment opportunities over two years. Under Part A of the scheme, first-time employees receive financial assistance of up to Rs 15,000 in two instalments. Under Part B, employers receive incentives of up to Rs 3,000 per employee per month for every additional worker employed. It provides incentives for up to four years to eligible manufacturing employers and for up to two years in other sectors. By putting money directly into workers' pockets, PMVBRY rewards work, makes jobs more attractive, and helps families remain financially secure. Financial incentives for employers can generate positive cyclical impacts on industrial growth.

PMVBRY's success is now being marked through a nationwide event. Today, Prime Minister Modi will disburse incentives worth Rs 2,400 crore to 15 lakh beneficiaries through direct benefit transfer. Simultaneously, events across 200 major industrial clusters will see appointment letters distributed to beneficiaries, and employers felicitated for creating opportunities.

As India moves towards the centenary of Independence, it is sending a clear message to the world: Its greatest strength is its young population. Twelve years of reforms have been driven by a strong partnership between employees and employers. The Modi government has recognised both as equal partners in nation-building, ensuring workers are protected, enterprises are empowered, and the benefits of growth are widely shared.

As India advances towards Viksit Bharat, employees and employers will continue to serve as the twin engines of growth, prosperity, and opportunity. "*Rozgar ho ya karobaar, saath hai Bharat sarkar*."

The writer is Union Minister of Labour & Employment and Youth Affairs & Sports

THE INDIAN EXPRESS

The Ideas Page

FRIDAY, JUNE 19, 2026

DIS/AGREE

THE BEST OF BOTH SIDES

A weekly column, which offers not this-versus-that, but the best of both sides, to inform the debate

ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

Court may have set a figure, but what's the value of unpaid domestic work?

SC verdict first step but has class blinkers

NEETHA N

THE RECENT Supreme Court ruling acknowledging the contribution of women "homemakers" is definitely a significant step in recognising the invisible and unpaid work of women in the country. Valuation of women's contribution to unpaid housework and care work is riddled with issues, as it is always entangled with familial relations. The compensation of Rs 30,000, as the ruling mentions, is a notional figure and thus can be seen as an acknowledgement of the priceless value of the labour of women that is otherwise largely underestimated. This large-scale underestimation of women's contribution to housework is evident in the cash transfer schemes that various political parties and state governments have offered or are offering to women in multiple states, which mostly range between Rs 1,000 and Rs 2,500 per month. The poor honoraria paid to community workers, be they Anganwadi workers, ASHAs or others, is another example. It is critical to flag this ongoing undervaluation of women's work while they are actively contributing to nation-building, whether as homemakers or as care workers.

While the judgment has surely opened up the way for a discussion on women's unpaid and undervalued work and their contribution to the economy, it raises multiple concerns. The first is the anxiety that many scholars of women's studies have raised, ever since the campaign on Wages for Housework in the 1970s, of a possible reiteration of gendered roles. The discussions around cash transfer schemes recognising women's housework in various states also highlighted the possible adverse effect of such schemes on women's economic status, given the poor participation of women in employment. At a time when women's share in higher education has surpassed male shares, equipping women to break gendered norms, the terminology of "homemakers" may end up in deceleration or reversal of such positive changes.

The judgment acknowledging women's unequal housework and care - work burden highlights it as a reason for the low female labour force participation. However, it does not delve much into this aspect, but goes on reiterating women's contribution in building, nurturing and maintaining human capital and thus being nation-builders. The lack of choice for women, whether to shoulder gendered roles or not, does not find any mention amidst this glorification of their contribution to families and the economy. Women's labour force participation in urban areas is very low, lower than that of their counterparts in rural areas, and much below male rates. In 2024-25, as per the PLFS data, the urban workforce participation rate of women (ages 15 plus) was only about 26 per cent, as against 45 per cent for rural women. Notably, the male-female difference was about 47 percentage points, with male participation rates at 73 per cent.

In rural areas, agriculture, the most important sector of women's employment, allows for intermittent paid and unpaid housework and care work, while in urban areas, such possibilities are few and conditional. The poor presence of married women and women with young children in jobs that are better paid is an issue that also needs attention. Studies in the context of flexible employment have also shown how women's choices are determined by gendered social and familial expectations around housework and care work. Without adequate policies that could help in the reduction and redistribution of housework and care work, women's employment outcomes will continue to be compromised.

The judgment is significant when read with the dismissal of the public interest petition *Penn Thozhilalargal Sangam Versus Union of India*, filed by 10 trade unions of domestic workers on the issue of minimum wages. This petition was disposed of by the Supreme Court this year, directing the unions to appeal to the state government. What seems contradictory to the current progressive position of the Court is the view that it held on the matter of minimum wages for domestic workers. The observation that minimum-wage regulation for domestic work can trigger an increase in litigation with unintended consequences, including the possibility of domestic workers losing their jobs, seems to contradict the current valuation argument. Or, is it that housework and care work performed by women in their own homes are worthier than the work carried out by poor women who are hired for such services? By entertaining the domestic workers' petition, the Court, alongside this landmark judgment, could have set the floor towards the valuation of housework and care work for different segments of women, whether part of the family or otherwise.

The writer is professor, Centre for Women's Development Studies, New Delhi

Give her rights in her lifetime

PAROMITA CHAKRABARTI

THEY SAY it is love. We say it is unwaged work." Thus begins Silvia Federici's foundational 1975 essay, "Wages Against Housework". Federici's Marxist-feminist argument was made in the context of Western industrial capitalism. Half a century later, and half a world away, the demand has shifted from wages to worth, from recognition to right.

The move from housewife (interchangeable for large periods of the 20th century, in thought if not in words, with house help/house elf) to homemaker has had a long, arduous journey. The marginal elevation has not altered much for the woman at the centre, still counted as the primary caregiver, still responsible, notionally at least, for the task of "housekeeping", still with very little to show for herself in terms of actual economic heft.

Last week, while hearing the case of a woman killed in a road accident in 2001, the Supreme Court took a decisive step towards addressing this anomaly. It held that the loss of domestic care provided by a homemaker constitutes a distinct category of compensation in motor-accident claims. The Court also arrived at a minimum figure of Rs 30,000 per month, a floor to be revised upward by 10 per cent every three years. The bench observed that care-giving work — mostly by women — is estimated to contribute about 15 to 17 per cent of the country's GDP, that in nurturing homes, values, and generations, homemakers perform the enduring work of nation-building. It is a landmark ruling that deserves to be celebrated. It also demands introspection.

For the purpose of the latter, let us turn to some basic accounting: Tally your monthly expenses for a cook, a part-time cleaner, a care provider for the elderly, and if you have young children, a nanny — more or less all the things a homemaker is, all at once, all day, every day. The figure, at least in Delhi, is likely to far exceed Rs 30,000. Now consider what the Court did not address, given that it falls outside the remit of the case. A woman who spends her lifetime managing a household, raising children, and enabling her spouse's career is worth Rs 30,000 a month only after she has been killed by a negligent driver. In her lifetime, she is worth nothing in terms of asset entitlement or wealth accumulation, at least not in any enforceable, quantifiable way.

This is an injustice with compounding consequences. When a woman steps out of the workforce — to follow a spouse to a new city, to raise children, to care for ageing parents — she exits a system that measures contribution in salaries and provident-fund deposits. Every year outside the formal economy widens the gap and reduces them to what economist Devaki Jain called "virtual non-entities in economic transactions". The apex court's ruling compensates for the absence of a homemaker's labour after death. It does nothing for the woman who is still alive, still holding up the home, still accruing none of the financial security that formal employment provides.

None of this is to suggest that the home be recast as a workplace or the spouse as a quasi-employer. It is an argument for rights and recognition, of the kind the Court itself offered: "It is ironic to describe a homemaker as dependent on earning members, when, in reality the household's functioning depends substantially on the homemaker." The homemaker, in other words, is the co-author of everything the household builds and everything it becomes.

To be fair, the judiciary has been pulling in the right direction. In February, the Delhi High Court observed that a wife's non-employment cannot be equated with indolence or deliberate dependence, that the assumption reflects a fundamental misunderstanding of marriage as a partnership: "Where one spouse earns income in the marketplace, and the other sustains the domestic sphere, the economic stability of the household is the result of combined, though differently manifested, contributions." In September 2025, a Delhi woman approached the High Court seeking a 50 per cent share in the matrimonial flat that her care had sustained for years. The division bench was candid about the bind it found itself in: It acknowledged that a homemaker's contributions "remain hidden and downplayed", called on the legislature to act, and then — because existing maintenance provisions lack the reach to cover asset-sharing — ruled against her.

Homemakers need more than a better payout at the Motor Accident Claims Tribunal that they themselves cannot enjoy. They need social infrastructure that eases the burden of care work, shares it more equitably, and values it more fully. They need community property laws that give them a share in liquid or income-generating marital assets; maintenance laws with teeth. And they need all of these in their lifetime.

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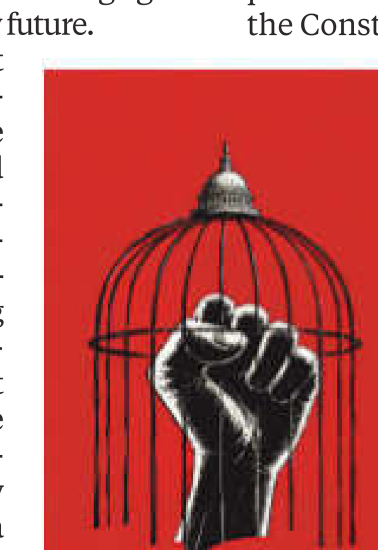
75 years on, the First Amendment still casts a long shadow

TRIPURDAMAN SINGH

JUNE 18, 2026 will mark 75 years since Rajendra Prasad gave his reluctant assent to the First Amendment — a "seismic shift" in India's constitutional architecture, the aftermath of which the country's pre-eminent legal scholar Upendra Baxi labelled the "Second Constitution". Few seem to have recalled the grim events of 1951, but it was a moment that continues to course through the nation's body politic, and one that has had profound and deleterious effects on its democracy and constitutional order.

On January 26, 1950, the Republic of India, described by the Oxford don Kenneth Wheare as the world's greatest experiment in democratic government, was inaugurated to great acclaim. Many had considered it an impossibility: Clement Attlee had even cautioned Jawaharlal Nehru against it, calling republicanism of the kind India was contemplating an alien import from Europe. At the heart of this transition lay the country's new constitution, containing what *The New York Times* approvingly termed "the most detailed document of fundamental rights found anywhere", widely seen to reflect India turning the page on its colonial past and taking a giant step towards a liberal new future.



It was a future that failed to materialise as imagined. By early 1951, the Nehru government had pronounced the Constitution to be the chief impediment in the way of its social policy and a stumbling block on the way to progress. The "magnificent Constitution" had, as he declared, been "kidnapped and purloined by lawyers". How had such a situation arisen? Three key legal battles fought around three key fundamental rights — the right to freedom of speech, the right to freedom from discrimination, and the right to property — shaped Nehru's assessment.

Government attempts to censor the *Organiser* (a scathing critic of its purported indifference towards the plight of refugees from East Bengal) and *Cross Roads* (a left-leaning weekly harshly criticising the brutal treatment of communist detainees) had been countermanded by the Supreme Court, which had also found the underlying legislation to be unconstitutional, knocking, to quote Sardar Patel, the bottom out of the laws used to control the press. In Madras, where a woman named Champakam Dorairajan had challenged the existing policy of strict caste- and community-based quotas, the High Court had found that religion, race, and caste could not be a basis for admissions to educational institutions and that reservation beyond that provided to the Scheduled Castes and Tribes was thus violative of the right to freedom from discrimination. The Patna High Court had struck the final blow in March 1951 when it held the Bihar Land Reform Act to be unconstitutional. Interestingly, rather than the right to property (as many had feared), it was the right to equality that proved to be the Act's undoing: The sliding scale of compensation it prescribed, where the rate went down as the size of the land parcel went up, was the culprit.

Collectively, the three judicial pronouncements had taken a sledgehammer to the government's ability to censor and regulate the dissemination of opinion, eroded its credibility, and thrown its social agenda into disarray. For Nehru, the very fact that the courts were willing to adjudicate on such matters was a step too far. It was his government, he argued, that represented the will of the people — and the Constitution was in the way. The result was the First Amendment.

It kneecapped the right to property and allowed the government to circumvent the right to freedom from discrimination in pursuit of social upliftment for "backward classes". Under the guise of protecting land reform legislation, it created the Ninth Schedule, a repository where laws could be placed to make them immune to judicial review even if they violated fundamental rights — described by the jurist A G Noorani as an "obscenity created by wilful resolve". More importantly, it introduced new grounds for restricting freedom of speech, including public order, incitement to offences, relations with foreign states, and the security interests of the state.

The consequences of the First Amendment have been far from benign. It dealt a crushing blow to the nascent forces of Indian liberalism, creating the constitutional plumbing for a vast armoury of repressive and coercive laws, including sedition. Moreover, it established the terrible precedent of retrospectively amending the Constitution to overcome adverse judicial pronouncements. The cavalier disregard for democratic propriety established a pattern for future egregiousness. Political power triumphed over constitutional order, eroding democratic norms even before the ink had dried on the original Constitution.

Disdain for civil liberties; prioritising the needs of the state; an aversion to public criticism cloaked in the language of "fake news" and "subversive activities"; a brute parliamentary majority riding roughshod over the protestations of the Opposition and civil society; a government agenda and party ideology elevated above fundamental rights; the claim that the wishes of the legislature should enjoy primacy over constitutional principles: The resonances with the contemporary world are more than semantic. Yet, there seems to be little inclination to register its 75th anniversary or revisit the long shadow it has cast on Indian democracy. Neither by its original supporters, now on the receiving end of the legal architecture it helped create, nor its original opponents, its prime targets now ensconced in the ruling establishment.

What we would do well to remember, however, is the prescient warning Syama Prasad Mookerjee, the man who led the opposition to the amendment and who could see that an uncontrollable weapon was being bequeathed to the future, issued to the government: "Maybe you will continue for eternity, in the next generation, for generations unborn; that is quite possible. But supposing some other party comes into authority. What is the precedent you are laying down?"

The writer is Ambizione Fellow, Graduate Institute, Geneva

NHAI GOES AI WAY

In-house system to flag faults in highway project reports

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, June 18

OFFICIALS WORKING with NHAI projects will now be able to identify defects in highways and get swift answers on ways to rectify them -- all with the click of a mouse.

In a move to check deficiencies in Detailed Project Reports (DPRs) of new highways, get faster analysis on road defects, identify faulty signages and to synthesise learnings from previous arbitration and project delays, the National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) has developed its own AI system. The system, deployed recently, works on the basis of NHAI's voluminous repository of documents such as circulars, act, Indian Roads Congress (IRC) codes and monthly reports.

It acts as an assistance tool by reducing the burden to go through multiple circulars, SOPs (Standard Operating Procedures) or IRC codes, which run into hundreds of pages, said officials. As of now, only NHAI officials have been given access to this system.

NHAI Chairman Santosh Kumar Yadav said that the access will also be granted to consultants and contractors soon after ensuring that there are no loopholes that could lead to misuse of the Authority's information.

"This system was needed because when we carried out the workflow study of Project Directors and regional officers of NHAI last year, we found that they have to be unnecessarily involved in a number of work, which can be easily done through AI tools. With this system in place, any official can check the defect of a highway by just uploading a photo. The system will quickly run through hundreds of guidelines, codes, notification, specifications and give the result," said Yadav.

He said that NHAI's AI system also addresses the problem of faulty DPRs, which become the foundation of any highways project. This problem has been repeatedly flagged by Union Minister of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH) Nitin Gadkari who said that road accidents and fatalities in India are increasing because of poor civil engineers, consultants, concessionaires and substandard DPRs.

"Our biggest problem is DPRs. For instance, In a Rs 2,000 crore project, there will always be a variation of Rs 200-300 crore. Besides, additional work has to be taken up. Now, we have to just upload the DPR of any project and the AI system will find the errors against IRC codes, MoRTH and standard policy circulars. Thus, these problems can be fixed in advance," said Yadav.

The NHAI's AI team has also developed a Technical Schedule Analyzer tool, which reviews DPR's schedule B and C documents and flags findings by severity and scoring completeness. Schedule B and Schedule C are core technical annexures that define the exact physical scope of the highway project.

Apart from this, NHAI also has an in-house chat-based AI agent, Margsarthi, where officials can place their queries. For instance, a field engineer can photograph a problem-hit site and ask Margsarthi what to do next as per the guidelines. The AI tool, connected to NHAI's datalake, went live on April 18. It has received over 50,000 queries from around 1,100 users so far. Over 40% of the questions were on circulars and documents.

The other tools are Kick-Off and MPR insights, which track every issues raised in kick off meetings and monthly project reports, flags critical issues and bottlenecks with a direct link back to the original minutes, and surfaces high-priority and overdue issues, each with a recommended action and a citation to the source page.

After tariff shock, Andhra's shrimp farmers face a new crisis as feed prices surge

Sreenivas Janyala
Hyderabad, June 18

MONTHS AFTER the US tariff shock, shrimp farmers in Andhra Pradesh are facing renewed financial pressure from a hike in aqua feed prices, significantly increasing production costs and prompting threats of protests.

According to industry estimates, feed maker companies have increased prices by Rs 12-16 per kg with effect from June 13. The hike comes at a time when shrimp farmers are still recovering from the disruptions and losses caused by the US tariffs.

Farmers operating aqua ponds, which require thousands of kilograms of feed every week, are now feeling the pinch.

"The cost of feed is up by at least Rs 12,000-Rs 14,000 per tonne of feed. Feed is 50 percent of the expenditure in a shrimp pond. From Rs 2-3 lakh, the investment has now risen to over Rs 4 lakh. How can farmers afford to pay such steep prices? They are already reeling from the US tariffs row a few months back," said Duggineni Gopinath, a leader of a shrimp farmers' association.

For their part, aqua feed companies cite rising fuel and transportation costs.

"Price rise was inevitable because prices of raw materials, fuel, and transportation have gone up. Some increased prices in February. Small companies cannot sustain without this price hike," said Alluri Krishna, owner of a Kakinada-based aqua feed company.

Shrimp farmers' leader Gopinath said about 2.5 lakh aqua farmers were reeling under the impact of the price rise. Last year, as US tariffs touched nearly 60 per cent, shrimp farmers either halted or scaled down production. The Andhra Pradesh government had estimated losses of about Rs 25,000 crore. While the withdrawal of the tariffs eased pressure on the sector, many farmers say they are yet to fully recover from the losses incurred during that period.

The state has 2.5 lakh aqua farmer families, of which 2 lakh are small and medium farmers. Another 30 lakh people depend on allied sectors

Shrimp economy

India exports approximately 8 lakh tonnes of shrimp a year, with Andhra Pradesh accounting for over 60 per cent of production. The state accounts for 80 percent of the country's shrimp exports and 34 per cent of marine exports, valued at around Rs 21,246 crore annually.

The state has 2.5 lakh aqua farmer families, of which 2 lakh are small and medium farmers. Another 30 lakh people depend on allied sectors. According to the Union Ministry of Commerce and Industry, India exported a record 17,81,602 MT of seafood worth US$ 7.38 billion (Rs 60,523.89 crore) in 2023-24, of which frozen shrimp alone accounted for 92 percent — a significant share from AP.

Even before the latest hike, per-acre investment in shrimp farming had already risen, driven by fears of diseases and viral infections in ponds, forcing farmers to spend more on medicines, disease prevention and pond management. The latest increase is now compounding that strain.

Farmers say they did not see the hike coming.

"Investments almost doubled due to the feed price hike but there is no corresponding rise in prices of shrimp so we have to absorb the losses. Small and medium farmers, who comprise the majority of the shrimp farmers, are the worst affected. Many of them have taken loans, and if profits are less, they will find it difficult to repay. Feed companies also broke the rule of always informing the farmers before increasing the prices," said B Balaram, who has two one-acre ponds in Palacole.

Y Satyam, another small shrimp farmer from Bhimavaram, said aqua feed prices have increased by nearly Rs 16 per kilogram between February and June, while shrimp market prices have fallen below production costs, causing heavy losses to farmers.

As prices continue to climb, the Andhra Pradesh government has sought to intervene, announcing a 15-member AP Shrimp Feed Ingredients Price Monitoring Committee with representatives from the State Institute of Fisheries Technology (SIFT), Marine Products Export Development Authority (MPEDA), Central Institute of Brackishwater Aquaculture (CIBA), A.P. State Aquaculture Development Authority (APSADA) and aqua farmers' associations.

"The committee will regulate the feed prices, put a check on unnecessary price hikes and bring transparency into pricing policies," Agriculture and Fisheries Minister K Atchannaidu said.

EBOLA SCARE IN KERALA

52-yr-old woman who travelled from South Sudan hospitalised with symptoms

India has not reported any confirmed Ebola case since the virus outbreak in parts of Africa

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, June 18

A 52-year-old woman from Kerala, who recently travelled from South Sudan, has been admitted to the Medical College Hospital in Kottayam with suspected symptoms of Ebola.

Officials at the medical college said the patient displayed symptoms of Ebola and had a travel history that included Sudan. "Samples have been collected and dispatched for laboratory investigation. We are awaiting the test reports for final confirmation," an official said.

The woman, who was first treated at a private hospital in Kottayam district's Pala, was moved to the government medical college on Wednesday night. She had developed a fever, headache, muscle pain and a sore throat.

Health Minister K Muraleedharan said the woman had travelled alone from Sudan to India via Uganda. Her family is in Pala in Kottayam district. "We have made all arrangements to meet any eventuality. However, there is no ground for panic at this stage. The woman has been admitted to an isolation room in the medical college," he said.

India has so far not reported any confirmed cases of Ebola. Last month, Union Minister of Health and Family Welfare Jagat Prakash Nadda reviewed preparedness and surveillance measures for Ebola disease in view of the recent outbreak in some parts of Africa.

At the outset, the Union Health Minister said, "India has not reported any case of Bundibugyo Ebola disease to date." However, following the declaration of Ebola as a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC) by the World Health Organisation (WHO) and Public Health Emergency of Continental Security (PHECS) by the Africa CDC, the Government of India is closely monitoring the Ebola situation in Africa and has proactively intensified surveillance and preparedness measures across the country as an abundant precaution to safeguard public health, authorities have said.

Subsequently, the Health Ministry has issued a special health alert across the country in response to the Ebola situation in the African nations of the Democratic Republic of Congo, Uganda, and South Sudan. Travellers arriving from these countries were advised to strictly follow the prescribed health and safety guidelines.

• MODI-TRUMP G7 MEETING

Conciliatory signs from Trump, but unpredictability frames challenge

SHUBHAJIT ROY

WHEN PRIME Minister Narendra Modi last met US President Donald Trump — at the White House in February last year — both sides discussed a trade deal aimed at lowering tariffs and set a bilateral trade target of $500 billion.

The months that followed saw bilateral relations plumbing new depths, largely driven by steep US tariffs and Trump's claims of brokering a ceasefire during Operation Sindoor.

Sixteen months after that White House meeting, Modi and Trump met for the first time at the French resort town of Evian Wednesday, on the sidelines of the G7 leaders' summit. After months of strained ties, the meeting projected a positive path ahead.

How the ties plummeted

The first flashpoint was Operation Sindoor. Trump claimed he had brokered the ceasefire between India and Pakistan. in a tough phone call with Trump, Modi rejected the US President's claims of any role. Pakistan, meanwhile, stepped up efforts to woo Trump. It thanked him for the ceasefire and cut cryptocurrency and critical mineral deals with his family members.

The lowest point, arguably, came when the US imposed 50% tariffs on India in August — 25% were in response to Indian tariffs and the rest was for buying Russian oil. This forced India to cut energy imports from Russia, though the US later issued a sanctions waiver.

In September, Trump raised the annual fee for H1-B visas to $100,000 — making it prohibitively expensive for tech companies to hire Indian professionals in the US. This month, a US judge struck down the fee, though the administration may appeal in the Supreme Court.

PM Modi during the G7 summit on Wednesday. AP

India's efforts

Though the Trump administration used economic leverage as a punitive measure against India, New Delhi kept working the phones.

By February, India and the US arrived at a framework that would lead to a trade deal. By then, India's imports from Russia had also dipped. In the meantime, Delhi started engaging with Trump. Modi welcomed the US President's efforts to bring in a ceasefire in the war in Gaza, and his efforts to end the Russia-Ukraine war.

By the end of February, however, another war broke out — one started by the US and Israel against Iran. The attack prompted Iran to effectively close the Strait of Hormuz, setting off a global energy shock.

In May, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio arrived in Delhi in an attempt to repair bilateral relations. But the recent killing of three Indian seafarers in the Gulf by the US navy created more tensions, exacerbated by Rubio's response.

MENDING FENCES

- The strategic trust developed over the last two-and-half decades with the US has taken a beating.
- Both sides will now have to work on its relationship to regain the lost trust.
- Delhi will hope that Trump's conciliatory statements are a signal to mend fences.

The Modi-Trump meeting

Keeping in mind this volatile context, the Trump-Modi bilateral meeting marked a significant moment. These are some takeaways from India's engagement with the US over these months and the latest meeting:

FIRST, Trump has ripped up the international system, and New Delhi is not immune to any actions he undertakes — either in his neighbourhood (Venezuela or Cuba) or far away (Iran). The war in West Asia has disrupted the Indian economy. But Trump's actions in Venezuela have allowed India to import oil from the South American country after a hiatus.

SECOND, Trump may be mercurial and unpredictable, but understands the sensitivities of Indian government and its politics. So he was effusive about Modi, did not push back on the issue of seafarers' deaths due to the US navy — as was done by Rubio — maintained his welcoming posture for skilled Indian professionals, and vowed security support for India in the face of threats.

THIRD, New Delhi's assessment is that Trump is willing to manage China on his own, and doesn't need any allies or like-minded partners like the Quad. The US President has reached out to his Chinese counterpart Xi Jinping, has promoted the concept of G2 (US and China), and is aware of Beijing's through critical mineral leverage, AI progress and manufacturing prowess. So, India needs to engage with China as well as assert its redlines, with help from like-minded partners.

FOURTH, India also understands that Trump needs to be managed for the next three years, and an openly confrontational approach or submissive behaviour doesn't work. Modi's approach — crediting him for peace efforts while working on a trade deal to limit tariffs — is the best possible strategy.

FIFTH, as the US limits its access, New Delhi wants to keep its choices open — with Europe, Australia, Japan, Singapore, Gulf monarchies and other like-minded partners for capital, technology and destination for Indian students, workers and professionals.

• US-IRAN INTERIM AGREEMENT

Iran gets 'understanding', world gets Hormuz, Trump gets his exit

Nuclear issue, Strait of Hormuz, sanctions: A point-by-point look at a pact that sets broader terms for US-Iran ties

EXPERT EXPLAINS

BASHIR ALI ABBAS

SENIOR RESEARCH ASSOCIATE, COUNCIL FOR STRATEGIC AND DEFENSE RESEARCH, NEW DELHI

The US and Iran signed a 14-clause Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to begin 60 days of negotiations for a final deal on June 17 and 18, respectively.

Unlike the 2015 Barack Obama-era nuclear agreement, the 2026 MoU indicates that the final agreement would both address the Iranian nuclear programme and set the terms of the US-Iran political relationship. These terms potentially make the Islamic Republic stronger than it has ever been since 1979, allowing it greater economic relief and the necessary geopolitical consent to build-up conventional military capabilities that can reshape West Asia's balance of power.

Here is a breakdown of the key points, what each side has promised, and what it says about their respective positions after months of conflict.

CLAUSE 1: End to hostilities on all fronts including Lebanon

This is the principal war termination clause. Compared to the April 8 ceasefire, the MoU signed by US President Donald Trump and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian cements Lebanon's integration with the US-Iran cessation of hostilities.

The 60-day interim period naturally bears the risk of resumed Israeli bombardment of Lebanon. But, Iran accepted US incentives (immediate removal of naval blockade in the Strait of Hormuz) to refrain from resuming hostilities against Israel/US targets, despite having committed to respond to Israel's bombing of Beirut. This set a new precedent in terms of what Iran can accept.

CLAUSE 2: No interference in internal affairs

The immediate import of this clause is the removal of Trump's rationale for resuming attacks on Iran. Between January 13 (when Trump stated that "help is on its way" in support of Iranian anti-government protestors) and February 28 (war initiation), Washington's rationale oscillated between "regime change" and de-nuclearisation. The clause is, thus, imperative in Tehran's view.

CLAUSE 3 contains a crucial provision allowing both sides to extend the 60-day period before a final agreement, with mutual consent.

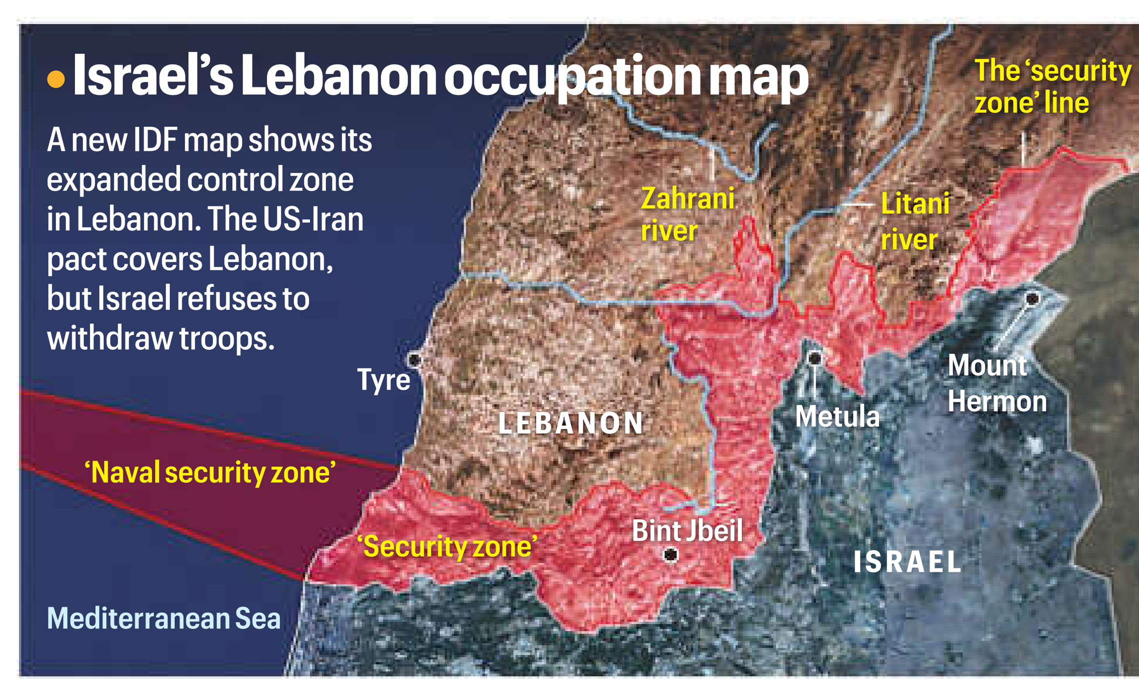
CLAUSE 4: Removal of US blockade

By June 16, the US Navy had already effectively withdrawn its blockade. In functional terms, withdrawal would refer to the remaining US Carrier Strike Groups in the Strait of Hormuz.

CLAUSE 5: Passage through Hormuz

Iran will allow unconditional transit passage to shipping in the Strait of Hormuz. However, it is the provision allowing Iran (and Oman) to define the future administration of the Strait that meets Iran's consistent demand that the Strait cannot return to its pre-war status.

US President Donald Trump signs the Iran MoU at the Palace of Versailles. Secretary of State Marco Rubio and France President Emmanuel Macron are also seen. PTI



Oman and Iran can reach a joint framework that can potentially mimic Turkish fee arrangements for the Dardanelles and Bosphorus Straits under the Montreux Convention. Since about 20-25% of oil and 20% of gas shipping globally relies on the Strait of Hormuz, estimated annual revenue could exceed $11-13 billion.

CLAUSE 6: $300-billion plan for reconstruction of Iran

The reconstruction initiative, to be developed by the US and its regional partners, is significant and a key distinguishing element from past negotiations for the 2015 Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) for limiting Iran's nuclear programme. The $300-billion fund will act as Iran's avenue to re-access the international economy. It also contains incentives for businesses linked to both Trump and Steve Witkoff, the investor and US Special Envoy to the Middle East.

CLAUSE 7: Sanctions relief in final deal

This clause, providing will have to address several categories of US unilateral sanctions on Iran, including those on the energy and shipping sectors. A *Wall Street Journal* estimate suggests that Iranian oil and fuel sales could generate around $60 billion in annual revenue. Washington will also have to address the interlinkage of three types of sanctions — on Iran's nuclear activities, counter-terrorism related sanctions and designations.

CLAUSE 8: Iran to not procure or develop nuclear weapons

The clause reaffirms Iran's commitment not to pursue a nuclear programme. This reflects a continuity in Iran's position since 2003. The core distinguishing factor from the JCPOA negotiation timeline (roughly 2013-15) is Iran's stockpile of 60% enriched uranium, which it did not possess at the time. Now, the MoU evidently does not mandate Iran to transfer its enriched nuclear material to any third country. This is a significant divergence from the original US position.

With fundamental changes to Iran's nuclear programme having been forced through US action, it is Iran's other shifts since 2018 that will have to be addressed.

Trump withdrew the US from the JCPOA back in 2018. Tehran formally terminated its remaining commitments after its October 2025 expiry and has, over time, withdrawn from other international monitoring protocols.

CLAUSE 9: Status quo until final deal

While this is meant to secure the gains of the MoU, none of the 14 clauses contain any reference to negotiations over ballistic missiles or Iran's relationships with regional non-state actors. On July 17, Trump also implied his willingness to let Iran retain ballistic missile capabilities. Here, too, the US President has moved significantly from his rationale for his 2018 withdrawal from the JCPOA.

CLAUSE 10 (**sanctions waivers**) acts as an interim arrangement before Clause 7 (**sanctions removal**) is operationalised.

CLAUSE 11: US unfreezes Iranian assets

Iran's frozen funds in foreign banks and holdings amount to over $100 billion. Around $12 billion has reportedly already been unfrozen and made available to Iran.

CLAUSE 12 provides for creating a mechanism to monitor the implementation of the MoU. This matters for the operationalisation of Clause 3, which allows mutually decided extensions to the 60-day window.

CLAUSE 13 sets a hierarchy of mutual priorities during the 60 days.

FINALLY, CLAUSE 14 provides for a binding UN Security Council Resolution for endorsing the deal. This is notable because it comes despite the Trump administration's disdain for the UN's mechanisms.

The JCPOA was endorsed by a UNSC resolution 2231, whose binding nature was affirmed in the text through Article 25 of the UN Charter. While the new UNSC Resolution will have to be similar, Iran could potentially seek fail-safe arrangements.

MoU a setback; the options now for Israel, its PM

YASHEE

WITH THE US-Iran Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) signed, President Donald Trump has posted on Truth Social that the "fools" who think he hasn't been tough enough on Iran "are either jealous, bad people, or stupid". This is unfortunate for his ally Israel, where a large section does believe that the MoU is very generous to Tehran.

"The mood in Israel is a mixture of anger, suspicion, and humiliation right now. The hawks in the ruling coalition are denouncing the deal as bad or non-binding, with some on the right wing accusing Trump of abandoning Israel. The Opposition calls it a strategic failure. The deeper mood is that Israel fought hard, but Washington and Tehran may now be defining the exit," Yonatan Touval, an analyst with the Israeli thinktank Mitvim, told *The Indian Express*.

Israel has insisted that despite what the MoU says, it won't stop its Lebanon campaign, which it says it is fighting the armed wing of the Hezbollah, a Shia group supported by Iran.

What is the road ahead for Israel?

The MoU says that Iran and US will negotiate a final deal within 60 days. For Israel, the immediate job will be to use these 60 days to secure more favourable terms, while maintaining cautious freedom of action in Lebanon.

"There is almost zero chance that Israel just stops everything in Lebanon tomorrow. Even if there is a ceasefire, it will take time to negotiate and implement. In the 60 days, Israel would try to press the US for better terms, regarding Iran's enriched uranium, enrichment facilities and centrifuges for example, in any final deal," Dahlia Scheindlin, a Tel Aviv-based political analyst, told *The Indian Express*.

Israel and Lebanon are holding parallel negotiations for peace, mediated by the US, but have not made substantial progress. "Israel now faces a real dilemma: whether to insist on preserving unilateral freedom of action, at the risk of friction with Washington, or to accept the MoU's de-escalatory logic and try to convert military gains into an enforceable Lebanese-state framework. The sensible course is not endless attrition, but a harder version of diplomacy: codified red lines, rapid response to immediate threats, US-backed enforcement, Lebanese Army responsibility, and no return to a Hezbollah military presence along the border," Touval said.

Israel has attacked Lebanon multiple times, each time aiming to defeat the Hezbollah, which manages to survive. What are its goals in Lebanon now?

Touval said this would involve Hezbollah "pushed away from the Israel-Lebanon border, stripped of open military freedom in the south, unable to fire rockets/drones at Israel, and reduced from a forward-deployed border army into a hostile Lebanese political actor, still dangerous inside Lebanon but no longer positioned to threaten Israel directly from the border."

What does the MoU mean for Netanyahu?

The MoU chips away at two of Netanyahu's core strengths — his 'tough on security' posturing, and his friendship with Trump. His actions in Gaza and Lebanon have dented Israel's image, without delivering on the promises of a defeated Iran and a defeated Hezbollah. And the timing couldn't have been worse, with elections around three months away.

Scheindlin said it was high time for Netanyahu to learn how to convert military gains into diplomatic ones. "This government has little trust in political processes. Even in Lebanon, they believe force is the only way," she said. But elections are due in a few months, could policy change if the prime minister changes? "So far, the Opposition has been claiming that it would have fought the same wars, but better. If there is a new government, it would need a new, bold vision for peace. However, there is indeed an expectation that a government not headed by Netanyahu would be more restrained," Scheindlin said.

And what do the voters of Israel want? "A large section of Israelis has become conditioned to want complete military victory. After October 7, people think such an attack could happen any day, there is this life and death attitude to everything. But it is inexcusable for a government to think like that. The government's job is to take a long-term, strategic view," she said.

• CLIMATE

Why the monsoon's progress has stalled over Maharashtra

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, June 18

IT HAS been a fortnight since the official commencement of the southwest monsoon season, but its performance has largely been sub-nominal so far. All-India rain was 38% below average between June 1 and 17.

The June-September southwest monsoon brings more than 70% of India's annual rainfall. The monsoon arrives over the Andaman Sea in the third week of May and advances into the mainland through Kerala, generally by June 1. It then advances in surges and reaches north Uttar Pradesh, Delhi and its neighbouring areas by the end of June, and covers the entire country by July 15. But an early or timely onset of the monsoon does not guarantee good rainfall or its distribution, or vice versa.

How has the monsoon progressed?

After onset over Kerala on June 4, the southwest monsoon progressed for four consecutive days. It advanced early into parts of the west coast, including Karnataka and Goa, but marked a delayed onset over most regions in northeast India.

The rainfall intensity over Kerala, southern Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Lakshadweep, and the whole of northeast India picked up in early June, but did not sustain for long. Upto June 10, the southwest India region recorded a 8% rain surplus.

Maharashtra's wait for the monsoon has now gotten longer, and there are no clear indications of possible onset yet. The latest monsoonal advance was on June 8, over parts of south Konkan and adjoining areas of south Madhya Maharashtra.

Overall, the Arabian Sea branch of the monsoon appears to be making slower progress this year compared to the Bay of Bengal branch.

After June 8, the monsoon advance continued mainly along eastern India regions. On June 15, the monsoon advanced into the remaining parts of Andhra Pradesh, West Bengal, Telangana, Odisha, Jharkhand and Bihar.

Why has it slowed over Maharashtra?

FIRST, monsoonal winds from the Arabian Sea since the onset period have weakened. Instead, stronger northerly or northwesterly dry winds are dominating the region and acting as barriers for the incoming, weak monsoonal winds. Moreover, these weak monsoon wind flows lack a strong surge from the Arabian Sea. It is these monsoon pulses that drive moisture and cause widespread rainfall while also helping the monsoon advance.

SECOND, cross-equatorial wind flow over the western Indian Ocean and Arabian Sea has weakened. These winds pump in moisture, aiding the monsoon's advance.

THIRD, the monsoon requires the support of other weather systems. These can be in the form of low-pressure areas or cyclonic circulations, either present over the Arabian Sea, the Bay of Bengal or an offshore trough (low-pressure belt) parallel to the west coast. All of these are now absent.

FOURTH, the southwest monsoon also requires favourable global weather factors. One such system is the Madden-Julian Oscillation (MJO), an eastward propagating wind and cloud band originating in the Mediterranean Sea. When MJO is in the favourable phase, it causes rainfall over India. However, that is not the case now.

How will the monsoon advance now?

Since June 16, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) has not released any updates on monsoon advancement over Maharashtra. This not only indicates a delayed monsoon onset but also greater uncertainty over its likelihood.

The monsoon is most likely to advance next over Telangana, Odisha, Jharkhand, Bihar, and some parts of Chhattisgarh sometime during the next four to five days, the IMD said Thursday.

• Rain shortfall in the West

Subdivision	Rainfall	Rainfall departure
Konkan and Goa	56.8 mm	-81%
Madhya Maharashtra	15.8 mm	-80%
Marathwada	26.9 mm	-62%
Vidarbha	19.2 mm	-72%

38%
All-India rainfall deficit between June 1-17

SOURCE: INDIA METEOROLOGICAL DEPARTMENT; **DURATION: JUNE 1-17**

MARITIME TRAFFIC VIA STRAIT OF HORMUZ EXPECTED TO PICK UP AFTER US-IRAN INITIAL PEACE DEAL

Govt may roll back emergency fuel measures if tensions ease

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 18

WITH THE US-Iran MoU raising hopes of normalisation of energy flows through the Strait of Hormuz, emergency measures taken since early March to ensure adequate fuel supply security to the most critical sectors and consumer segments are now likely to be reviewed and rolled back once the government feels the situation is stable and nearing normalcy, according to a senior government official.

The West Asia war, which broke out on February 28 with the US and Israel striking Iran, led to an effective halt in vessel movements through the critical chokepoint of the Strait of Hormuz, which accounted for a fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas flows.

The strait is a narrow waterway that connects the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea, and is the primary route to evacuate energy supplies from the broader Gulf region.

Given the supply squeeze, the government announced several measures, which included prioritising natural gas supply to some priority sectors while reducing it for others, reducing liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) allocation for commercial and industrial consumers to ensure cooking gas availability to households, increasing mandatory waiting periods of LPG refills by households, and measures to prevent hoarding of petrol and diesel.

"We have been reviewing the situation on a daily basis... all the measures we took during this crisis period will be reviewed and once we feel confident that the situation has normalised, we will start rolling those back," the government official said.

"To ensure supplies to some priority segments, we were forced to curtail supply to some other sectors. We want to resume supplies at regular levels to those sectors as well, and it will be done once things normalise," the official added.

Around 40% of India's crude oil imports, 60% of its LNG imports, and a whopping 90% of its LPG imports regularly came from West Asia through the strait.

• FUEL RESET

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SURGE IN in international prices forced India to import oil and gas at extremely high rates, as the country had to prioritise supply security over price considerations

The country's dependence on imports stands at over 88% for oil, 60% for LPG, and about 50% for natural gas, which is imported as LNG. India is among the top importers of crude oil, LNG, and LPG.

While highly diversified crude sourcing helped ensure adequate oil, petrol, diesel, and jet fuel availability, the government was forced to ration gas supplies to certain industries and commercial consumers.

Moreover, the surge in international prices forced India to import oil and gas at extremely high rates, as it had to prioritise supply security over price considerations.

With maritime traffic through the strait expected to pick up following the US-Iran initial peace agreement, huge volumes of oil and gas stranded in the Persian Gulf could hit the international market in the coming months, which is likely to cover the shortfall in global supply and lead to a glut a few months if regular oil and gas exports from the region resume.

Since supplies are likely to be more than adequate in the coming months, unless the peace agreement fails, there will be no reason for the government to continue with the emergency measures, industry sources said.

"A reopening of the Strait of Hormuz would represent a major milestone for global energy markets, but the impact on India is likely to vary significantly across commodities. While India remains one of the largest importers of Middle Eastern hydrocarbons, crude and LNG imports have proven relatively resilient throughout the disruption, unlike LPG... As a result, the recovery is likely to be sequential, with LPG flows normalising first, followed by LNG and crude," said Sumit Ritolia, manager, modelling & refining at commodity market analytics firm Kpler.

Finance ministry ratifies EPF rate of 8.25% for FY26

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, June 18

THE FINANCE ministry has ratified 8.25% interest rate for 2025-26 for over 7.8 crore contributing subscribers of the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPF), maintaining it at the same level as recommended by the Central Board of Trustees (CBT) in March, a government official said on Thursday.

CBT, the top decision-making body of EPFO, typically recommends the rates annually around February-March, after which the recommendations are sent to the finance ministry for approval.

The official said a notification by the Ministry of Labour and Employment on the interest rate is expected later this month. The labour ministry is also expected to launch EPFO 2.0, a revamped digital ecosystem, by the end of June, which will allow its subscribers to withdraw 75% of their EPF corpus to their bank account via UPI or ATM.

Every EPFO member will be able to avail the UPI facility through the BHIM app, with the existing guardrails for UPI transactions to apply as they are. The facility is expected to help blue-collar workers in the EPFO ambit who may not otherwise be able to avail the withdrawal process through the online portal.

The proposed rollout of the new facility comes after the EPFO announced liberalisation of its withdrawal norms after its Board meeting in October last year, streamlining the withdrawal categories from 13 to three: essential needs (illness, education, marriage), housing needs, and special circumstances.

The Indian Express had reported in March that EPFO's CBT, headed by Labour and Employment Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, had recommended an interest rate of 8.25% to its over 7.8 crore contributing subscribers for the third straight year in 2025-26. The 8.25% recommendation by the board came despite EPFO's own investment sub-committee and the Ministry of Finance suggesting that the interest rate be cut to 8.10% for 2025-26.

(With inputs from PTI)

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